

Chapter 85-6

After Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi were seated, Su Zhe had the server bring out the dishes.

Very soon, the table was piled with all kinds of dishes. Sheng Yu nestled in Su Nan's arms and started eating.

Su Zhe cleared his throat and began: "Then today, we officially become one family."

Xu Qingzhu looked at him, picked up the wine glass in front of her, poured just a little to show her sincerity, and called Su Zhe "uncle."

After going around greeting everyone, the last one remaining was Su Yao.

Su Yao's eyes had already turned red as she looked at her. Xu Qingzhu had originally been looking at her from across the table, and seeing Su Yao's reddened eyes, she couldn't help but feel sad along with her.

When it came to Su Yao's turn, Xu Qingzhu stood up and sat down beside Su Yao, then took the initiative to hold Su Yao's hand. But the word "Mom" just wouldn't come out no matter what.

"Are you... really my daughter?" Su Yao asked.

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Yes."

The private room fell completely silent. Everyone was watching the two of them. Xu Qingzhu's tears fell.

She had thought she was strong enough—strong enough not to cry even when seeing Su Yao cry.

But she hadn't expected that when she held Su Yao's hand, she would be the first one to cry.

Su Yao hurriedly grabbed tissues to wipe her tears, comforting her in a low voice: "Little Zhuzi¹, don't cry."

This intimate nickname made Xu Qingzhu's heart ache unbearably.

She had followed Sheng Linlang's words through the long love story of Sheng Qinglin and Su Yao, and she knew what Su Yao had experienced.

Now sitting beside Su Yao, Xu Qingzhu hadn't expected to hear "Little Zhuzi."

Her name was Qingzhu—unyielding and unbreaking, forever verdant.

It was the name her parents had given her, full of hope.

And for a very long time, Su Yao had kept "Little Zhuzi" in her heart and mind, yet had no one to miss. Year after year, she would look at the verdant bamboo outside her window, not knowing who she was longing for.

In this moment, all that longing finally had a place to land.

Xu Qingzhu opened her mouth and called out with difficulty: "Mom."

Su Yao nodded in acknowledgment: "Ai."²

Sheng Yu, who was nearby, jumped down from Su Nan's arms and toddled over on her little short legs to hand Su Yao a tissue. "Mama, don't cry."

After looking at Xu Qingzhu, she handed another tissue to Xu Qingzhu. "Nice-smelling jiejie, don't cry."

This made Xu Qingzhu not know whether to laugh or cry.

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The dinner went smoothly. Xu Qingzhu sat beside Su Yao the entire time.

She had originally thought that as she was now grown up, she could take care of Su Yao. But unexpectedly, Su Yao kept putting food on her plate the whole time—she was the one being taken care of.

Watching their reunion from inside the private room, Liang Shi thought of her grandparents. It felt a bit stuffy staying in the room, so she used the excuse of going to the restroom to leave.

She went to the corridor to get some air, leaning against the wall by herself in a daze.

Suddenly, a crisp voice rang out in the corridor: "Why can't you break up with her? Whatever she can give you, I can give you too."

Liang Shi glanced sideways and saw a woman standing on the stairs wearing a black slip dress, her long hair draped over her shoulders. She was like a thorny black rose.

Liang Shi felt this wasn't a place to linger and was about to leave, but the woman had already hung up the phone and instead asked: "Hey, got a light?"

It didn't sound polite at all, but it didn't come across as arrogant either.

As it happened, Liang Shi had a lighter in her coat pocket—a one-yuan lighter she'd bought downstairs at their residential complex to light incense.

Liang Shi hesitated for a few seconds but still chose to hand the lighter to her.

The woman pinched out a cigarette from her pack. Her red nails weren't tacky; instead, they had a kind of glamorous beauty.

She lit the cigarette but didn't return the lighter to Liang Shi. Instead, she pinched out another cigarette and offered it to Liang Shi. Liang Shi waved her hand. "I don't smoke."

The woman didn't push it. After taking a puff and blowing out a smoke ring, she then waved her hand and, looking somewhat dissatisfied, stubbed out the cigarette. "This cigarette is really harsh," she said with displeasure.

Liang Shi couldn't help but say: "Then why smoke it?"

"Didn't I just put it out?" the woman said. "You..."

Her words trailed off mid-sentence. She pointed at Liang Shi. "Wait, your face..."

"What about it?" Liang Shi asked.

The woman frowned. "Your eyes are quite pretty."

It was clearly meant as a compliment, but the way she said it was so bland that you couldn't tell it was a compliment.

Liang Shi also responded perfunctorily: "Thanks."

The woman put away her graceful and casual posture and returned the lighter to Liang Shi. "No need for thanks."

Then she looked at Liang Shi. "What's your name?"

"Liang Shi." Liang Shi answered. "Do you know me?"

"I don't." The woman's voice was cool and flippant. "But now I do, as of today."

She paused for a moment. "My name is Gu Yixue."

After saying this, she pulled open the door. As she was leaving, she chuckled softly: "Oh, by the way, eavesdropping on people's phone calls isn't a good habit."

Liang Shi: "..."

"If we meet again next time, I'll give you a more expensive lighter." Gu Yixue said.

Footnotes:

¹ **Little Zhuzi (小竹子):** An affectionate nickname meaning "Little Bamboo." "Zhu" (竹) means bamboo, which is also part of Xu Qingzhu's name. "Qingzhu" (清竹) means "clear/pure bamboo" or "verdant bamboo."

² **Ai (哎):** A Chinese interjection used to acknowledge being called, similar to answering "yes" or "here" when someone calls your name. It's a warm, familial response typically used by elders when a younger person addresses them.